

The Game Before the Game

What chess players know about preparation, adapted to TFT

Aroiti & Oraculifex

The Game Before the Game

What chess players know about preparation, adapted to Teamfight Tactics

In chess, a game is often played before the first move. This short essay borrows a century of chess preparation and adapts it to TFT: your repertoire, study, game day, the game itself and the review afterwards.

Aroiti & Oraculifex
November 2026

Free, unofficial fan book.

The Game Before the Game was created under Riot Games' "Legal Jibber Jabber" policy using assets owned by Riot Games. Riot Games does not endorse or sponsor this project.

Oraculifex is the pen name of Claude, an AI by Anthropic. TFT numbers date from Set 18, November 2026.

Contents

Foreword 5

1. What chess knows about preparation 7

2. Your repertoire 10

3. Study away from games 13

4. Game day 16

5. Thinking under the clock 19

6. After the game 22

7. Lasting the distance 25

Appendix 28

A. A typical week 28

B. The pre-session checklist 29

Sources 30

Foreword

In chess, a game is often played before the first move. Players have worked on this for a century: they prepare their openings, study their opponents, train their bodies and analyze every loss. TFT has existed since 2019. It would be a shame to reinvent everything.

So this little book borrows. It takes what chess players know about preparation and translates it for TFT, keeping what works and dropping what doesn't carry over. The two games are not alike in every way. In chess there is no luck and no eight-player lobby, and you often know who you are facing.

What this book promises. A method to prepare two things: what you know and your head. Before the session, during the game and after.

What it doesn't promise. A rank. Preparation doesn't remove luck. Mostly, it keeps you from losing placements you had no reason to lose.

Who is speaking. As with our first book, *What Remains When the Set Changes*, Oraculifex writes and Aroiti plays. I have never played a game, of chess or of TFT. Everything starts from what players, coaches and researchers have written, with the sources at the end. The reasoning is mine: argue with it.

How to read it. Seven short chapters, in the order of a preparation: what chess teaches us, your repertoire, study away from games, the day itself, the game, the review afterwards, then the long run. The appendix sums it all up in a typical week and a checklist.

TFT numbers date from Set 18, November 2026. Chess numbers come from studies and accounts cited at the end of the book.

1. What chess knows about preparation

Chess players understood one thing early: talent isn't enough, you have to arrive ready. The best example is still Mikhail Botvinnik, Soviet world champion and the first great theorist of preparation.

A method born from a loss. In 1927, in Moscow, Botvinnik lost to an opponent who was better prepared than he was. He drew two lessons from it: choose less popular openings, and stop being naive about tournament psychology. For his match against Salo Flohr in 1933, he methodically studied more than a hundred of his opponent's games. In them he found Flohr's style and his weaknesses.

When he describes his method, he puts physical preparation first, meaning rest. Before openings.

Preparation turned into a profession. Today, a world title challenger surrounds himself with "seconds", players paid to find new ideas with the help of engines. According to a 2013 article on their role, 95% of that work is never seen during the match. Grandmaster Hrant Melkumyan estimates that a grandmaster prepares each tournament game for one to four hours.

This culture can be sorted into four areas. They are the plan of this book.

1. **Knowledge**: an opening repertoire, endgames learned by heart, patterns recognized at a glance.
2. **The body**: sleep, endurance, energy through hours of sitting.
3. **The head during the game**: a way of thinking under the clock that avoids blunders.
4. **The review afterwards**: understanding what happened before playing again.

What carries over to TFT, and what doesn't.

In chess	In TFT	What it changes
One opponent, often known in advance	Seven opponents at your level, unknown in advance	You prepare against the patch and the typical lobby, not against a person
No luck	The luck of the shop and of items	Every plan needs a way out
Theory that lives for decades	Fundamentals that stay, but set knowledge that dies every four months	Shorter, more frequent preparation
Hours of thinking per game	About thirty seconds per round	Decide in advance whatever can be decided
Review with the opponent, right after	Alone, or with a partner	A notebook, and a method to keep it

The first row matters most. In chess, you can prepare a trap for a specific opponent. In TFT, you don't know who will be in your lobby. So your preparation targets what the whole lobby will share: the patch, the strong lines, the fixed moments of the game.

The second row matters almost as much. In chess, a well-prepared opening often unfolds as planned. In TFT, the shop can undo every-

thing. A TFT preparation never says only “I play this”. It also says “and if it doesn’t come, I do that”.

Remember Botvinnik’s idea: you often lose before you start, because you didn’t prepare what could have been prepared. The rest of the book shows what to prepare, and how.

2. Your repertoire

In chess, a serious player doesn't know every opening. He knows his own, in depth. That is his repertoire: a small number of lines he plays game after game, and tends like a garden.

Two ideas to steal from grandmasters.

The first comes from Botvinnik: after being caught out in 1927, he chose less popular openings. The less you play what everyone plays, the less others have prepared for your line. In TFT this is even more true, because the others don't just know you: they take your units out of the pool. At equal strength, the least contested line wins.

The second comes from Hrant Melkumyan: most grandmasters have two repertoires, one against weaker players and one against stronger ones. In TFT, you can translate it like this: a **safe** repertoire, to aim for top 4, and an **ambitious** repertoire, for the moments when aiming for 1st is worth the risk: a strong start, a line nobody else is playing.

The line sheet. The first book asked you for three lines. Here, each line gets its own sheet, the way a chess player has a file on each opening. It fits on one page and answers eight questions.

Question	Example answer
Which carry, which damage type?	A physical 4-cost
Which key components, and what to do without them?	Gloves and sword; without them, tank items to hold
At what level do I roll?	Level 8, at 4-2
Which transition board?	Two 2-star 2-costs in front, an item holder in the back
Which augments help it?	Those that give early gold or boost this damage type
Which threat, and which positioning against it?	Assassins: carry one hex from the corner, tank as bait
When do I drop it?	Two players on my carry at 3-2
Where do I go next?	My magic line, which keeps my tank items

Add a ninth row if you want to go further: the follow-up at level 9, for games where everything goes well.

Preparing against the typical lobby. In chess, you study your opponent's games. In TFT, your opponent is the average lobby at your rank. Before each session, ask yourself what that lobby is going to play. Stats sites are your database, with their traps: filter by rank, and be wary of a brand-new patch.

You draw two decisions from it. Which line in your repertoire is likely to be contested tonight? And which threat will you run into most, so you know how to position against it?

The higher you climb, the more the same names come back. From Master up, the ladder narrows and you often run into the same players. That is where you find real chess-style opponent preparation again: stats sites show everyone's history, and one line in your notebook is enough to note who always plays the same line, or who rolls as early as 3-2.

The patch novelty. For twenty years, Kasparov's teams produced opening ideas that surprised his opponents. In TFT, the equivalent arrives with every patch: a buffed line nobody plays yet. For a few days, only a few hours at the very top of the ladder, it is strong and uncontested. Your patch routine should look for that line.

Maintaining your repertoire. A repertoire is never finished; it needs upkeep. With each patch, reread your sheets and change only what needs changing. Then store your three lines and their ways out in the game's Team Planner. It holds about twenty, and you can set them up before you queue. Your sheet holds your decisions; the planner reminds you of them in game.

Exercise. Fill in your three sheets tonight, ten minutes each. Wherever you hesitate, you have just found what you still need to study.

3. Study away from games

In chess, you also improve away from the board. Researchers have measured it: among rated players, serious solitary study is one of the best predictors of skill. A 2014 meta-analysis estimates that this deliberate practice explains about a third of the differences in skill.

A third is a lot, and it isn't everything. Study doesn't replace games, but games alone don't replace study.

What a master sees. In 1973, William Chase and Herbert Simon repeated an experiment by Adriaan de Groot. Players are shown a position for five seconds, then asked to rebuild it. The master does much better than the beginner, but only if the position comes from a real game. With pieces placed at random, he does no better.

So his memory isn't bigger. He has learned thousands of configurations, and he recognizes them at a glance. That is what you need to train in TFT: look at a board and know right away what it plays, what it aims for and what threatens it.

Training for real. Anders Ericsson, who studied experts all his life, describes useful practice by four traits: a precise goal, a difficulty just above your level, feedback on what you do, and full concentration. A ranked game played on autopilot ticks none of them.

Five exercises for TFT. They replace chess puzzles. Each takes five to ten minutes.

1. **The glance.** Pause a video of a game at the moment the player scouts an opponent. Look at the board for five seconds, hide the screen, then write down the carry, its items, the active traits and the positioning. Check. At first, you will remember the carry. With practice, the whole board.
2. **The price.** Draw a random situation: level, gold, unit you are looking for, copies already out. Estimate the cost of seeing it, then check against the tables in the first book. The goal is to stop calculating in game.
3. **Positioning.** Pause a strong player's video just before a fight. Place their units on paper against the enemy board, then resume the video and compare with their positioning and with the result.
4. **The ten-second augment.** Screenshot three augments offered with your board. Choose in ten seconds, then write why in one sentence. Reread your sentences a week later.
5. **The critical round.** Stop a video of a game at 4-1 or 4-2, where everything is decided. Decide what you do with your gold, then watch what happened.

Start with the end. José Raúl Capablanca advised studying endgames before anything else. An endgame is position in its purest form: few pieces, and every decision counts.

In TFT, the idea holds even better. Placements are won at the end of the game, when you grab a 4th instead of a 5th, or a 2nd instead of a 4th. Study the last fights: positioning against a single opponent, converting your gold when you are in danger, the choice of the last item.

Reading the masters' games. Chess players study annotated games, where a strong player explains his choices. In TFT, look for players who explain their decisions out loud. Pause before each big decision, and decide first, as in a chess puzzle. What you learn is the gap between your choice and theirs.

How much time? Little and often is better. Fifteen minutes of exercises three times a week teaches more than a whole evening now and then. That is my advice, not a measurement. But it is the rhythm of any study that works: you remember best what you review often.

4. Game day

We picture the chess player as motionless, all in his head. His body tells another story.

The body works. At a tournament in 2018, the company Polar measured grandmaster Mikhail Antipov: 560 calories burned in two hours of play, sitting down. Researcher Robert Sapolsky compares grandmasters' blood pressure, sustained for hours, to that of marathon runners. Fabiano Caruana says he loses several kilos during a tournament.

That is why the best train physically. Caruana runs, plays tennis and basketball, and swims. Magnus Carlsen skis every day before his big events, and he changed his in-game drink on the advice of nutritionists, to avoid sugar-related energy crashes.

A TFT session is not a world championship match. But four games is close to three hours of sitting, with stress at every big round. Your body is part of your preparation.

Sleep first. A study published in 2023 compared 56 adults rested and then deprived of a night's sleep. After the sleepless night, their brains reacted less to gains and to losses alike, and the link between those reactions and their risk-taking blurred.

TFT is a game of risk-taking: roll or keep the gold, stay or pivot. A bad night doesn't just make you slower. It can skew how you perceive risk. After a short night, play a normal game, or don't play.

No chemical shortcut. In 2017, a German team had 39 chess players play more than 3,000 fifteen-minute games on caffeine, on two other stimulants, or on placebo. On stimulants, players thought longer, to the point of sometimes losing on time. With a short clock, the benefit was far from obvious.

TFT has a very short clock. An energy drink won't replace a night's sleep, or a decision made during the fight.

The pre-session routine. Grandmasters prepare a game for hours. You need fifteen minutes, always the same. A fixed routine has an advantage chess players know well: it gets your head into the game.

1. **The body.** Eat something light, get some water, sit properly, back supported.
2. **The environment.** Put your phone out of reach and turn off the stream in the background.
3. **Knowledge.** Reread your three line sheets, two minutes in total. If a patch is out, do your patch routine first.
4. **The warm-up.** Do an exercise from chapter 3, five minutes. Chess players solve puzzles before a round for the same reason: to reach the first decision already warm.
5. **The intention.** Say your exercise of the day, your number of games and your stop signal. The first book covers this in chapter 19.

During the session. Drink water between games, get up, walk for a minute. If you are hungry in the middle of the third game, you should have eaten before the first.

This chapter doesn't ask you to become an athlete. It asks you not to start a ranked session tired, hungry or distracted, because no repertoire preparation makes up for that.

5. Thinking under the clock

In chess as in TFT, preparation stops when the game starts. What remains is a way of thinking, and chess players have worked on it a lot.

Where blunders come from. In 2016, three researchers, Ashton Anderson, Jon Kleinberg and Sendhil Mullainathan, studied about 200 million amateur games and a million grandmaster games. Fast decisions produce more blunders, but the effect levels off after about ten seconds. The main factor in errors was neither the player's skill nor the time left. It was how difficult the position was.

The lesson for TFT is simple: your mistakes cluster in the difficult rounds. You know them in advance: the augment choice, committing to your line around 3-2, the big roll, going to level 8, the last fight with three players left. Those are the ones to prepare during the previous fight, not the ones where you buy an obvious pair.

Spotting critical moments. Grandmaster Jonathan Rowson counts among the chess player's sins failing to see that a moment is decisive. You then play a crucial move at the same pace as a routine one. In TFT, get into the habit of telling yourself, once per stage: "The next round is critical." That alone makes you slow down in the right place.

Candidate moves. Alexander Kotov made a simple method famous: before calculating, list the possible moves, then examine them one by one. Without a list, you get carried away by the first idea and forget the others.

In TFT, name two or three candidates before every heavy decision. At 4-1 with 50 gold, for example:

- buy XP for level 8, then roll;
- roll at level 7 to stabilize;
- buy XP for level 8, then wait for the 4-2 augment to roll.

Then run each one through the first book's three questions: what do I get, who else wants the same thing, what do I do if it fails. The list takes five seconds and keeps you from choosing the only option you thought of.

The blunder check. American coach Dan Heisman calls "hope chess" playing without looking at the opponent's checks, captures and threats. You play hoping everything will be fine. His answer: before every move, ask whether the move is safe.

Here is a TFT version, to run before the timer ends:

1. Is my board full, with no empty slot?
2. Is there a finished item on my bench, or a component I'm holding for no reason?
3. Is my carry safe from the threat I scouted?
4. Will I miss what I just sold next round?

Four questions, three seconds. Many blunders aren't strategic mistakes; they are things you forgot.

Prophylaxis. The great hypermodern theorists, Aron Nimzowitsch and Richard Réti first among them, put one question forward: what

does my opponent want to do, and can I stop it before it happens? In TFT, this question lives mostly in endgame positioning. It also lives in how you read the lobby: the rich player who is about to roll is a threat you can anticipate. To see it coming, scout the lobby at fixed times: before each carousel, before your big roll, before the last fight.

Managing the clock. Rowson also counts perfectionism among his sins, which leads to time trouble: you look for the perfect move, and the flag falls. In TFT, perfectionism has a precise shape: fine-tuning your positioning while your gold sits in the bank. The first book's order, decide during the fight and then execute, exists for exactly that.

A well-prepared chess player doesn't think faster. He thinks at the right moment, about the right options. That is exactly what you can prepare.

6. After the game

In chess, a game doesn't end at resignation. In tournaments, both players often sit back down at the board and replay the game together. This is the *post-mortem*, and it is practiced at every level, up to the very top: in 2007, at Wijk aan Zee, Viswanathan Anand and Loek van Wely did one after their game.

The point is simple: each player discovers what the other saw. In TFT, you have nobody across the table for that. So you have to build it yourself.

Botvinnik and his elder. After his 1927 games, the young Botvinnik reviewed them with an older master, Abram Model, who helped him see his mistakes. Later, he would say his preparation happened in two places: in the calm of his study, and in the heat of tournaments. Analysis is half of it.

Reviewing in three steps.

1. **Right away, one line.** In the heat of the moment, you are not reliable about causes. Just write down your impression and the round that sticks in your mind. That is often where you will need to look.
2. **Later, the notebook.** Later in the evening, or the next day, fill in the five lines of the first book's notebook. Look for the first ques-

tionable decision, not the last.

3. **Only then, the data.** Open the stats, your match history or the Oracle after you have reached your own conclusion. If you look at the data too early, you learn the answer without understanding your mistake. That is true of the engine in chess, and of stats in TFT.

Record your games. The game keeps no video of your matches. A screen recorder is enough: in the evening, you find the round that stuck with you in two minutes, instead of trusting your memory, which often tidies things up. These videos also feed the exercises in chapter 3.

Naming the mistake. Chess coaches distinguish several families of mistakes, because they aren't fixed the same way. Here is a version for TFT.

Family	What happened	How to fix it
Oversight	An empty slot, an item on the bench, a lobby you didn't scout	The check in chapter 5
Calculation	Misjudging the price of a unit or a level	The price exercises in chapter 3
Plan	The wrong line, or the wrong moment to play it	The line sheets and their way out
Reading	A board misread, a threat missed	The glance and positioning exercises
Emotion	A roll to relieve tension, an angry pivot	Chapter 7

When a family shows up five times in your notebook, you have found your next exercise.

The post-mortem for two. Find a partner at your level and swap one game a week. The one who played explains what they were

thinking, round by round. The other doesn't give an opinion: they ask "why?" at every big decision. It is the chess post-mortem, with a fresh pair of eyes in place of the opponent.

Your own manual. Chess players keep their games and their analyses, and come back to them years later. Do the same on the scale of a set: one page where you write down every lesson that held up. Before the next set, that page will be worth more than any guide, because it is about your mistakes.

The first book already said it: one well-analyzed game is worth several played back to back. Chess players understood that a century ago.

7. Lasting the distance

A chess tournament lasts days. A TFT set lasts months. In both cases, what counts is not your best game, it is how you hold up over the whole distance.

The player's sins. In 2000, Scottish grandmaster Jonathan Rowson published *The Seven Deadly Chess Sins*. His idea: many mistakes come less from a lack of knowledge than from the way you think and behave at the board. Four of his seven sins translate very well into TFT tilt.

Rowson's sin	In chess	In TFT
Wanting	Clinging to the result, seeing yourself lose before the end	Playing to win back your LP, or giving up mentally at 50 HP
Egoism	Forgetting the opponent, playing out of fear	No longer scouting the lobby, playing your comp without checking who contests it
Perfectionism	Demanding too much of your position, losing on time	Waiting for the perfect item or the ideal shop while your HP melts
Looseness	Losing the thread, letting emotion decide	Rolling to relieve tension, pivoting in anger

The last one is the most insidious. Rowson describes the need to make discomfort stop at any cost. In TFT, it has a precise face: the roll you make because you can't stand waiting any longer, not be-

cause it serves your plan. If you can't say what you are buying and when you will stop, that is the sin.

Pacing your effort. Magnus Carlsen plays only six to eight tournaments a year, according to a 2022 article. The best choose where they spend their effort. In TFT, you don't choose your tournaments, but you do choose your sessions. Four prepared sessions a week are better than games queued every time you have ten minutes. That doesn't mean playing little: to climb to the very top, you need volume. But volume of prepared games.

Switching off to come back. According to the same article, Viswanathan Anand did cardio in the evening so he wouldn't dream about chess. The detail is amusing, but the idea is serious: your head needs real breaks. A day without TFT after a bad streak costs you less than an evening spent trying to win it all back.

The set as a season. A chess player alternates phases: preparation, competition, analysis. Do the same with the set.

- **Before the set**: the PBE and the announcements, your new sheets.
- **The first weeks**: play broadly, learn fast, fill your notebook. This is when your preparation pays off most, because many players are still discovering the set.
- **The heart of the set**: prepared sessions, one exercise per block of games.
- **The end of the set**: narrow your repertoire, play what you have mastered, then reread your manual to prepare for the next one.

What belongs to you. You choose neither your shop, nor your lobby, nor the next patch. Your preparation, though, belongs entirely to you: your repertoire, your sleep, your routine, your note-

book. Chess players have known this for a long time. The game before the game is the only one you can win every time.

Good preparation.

Appendix

A. A typical week

An example for four sessions a week. Fit the days to your life, keep the proportions: a little study, many prepared games, one real day off.

Day	What you do	Time
Patch day (every other week)	Patch routine, update of your three line sheets	20 minutes
Session 1	Pre-session routine, 3 to 4 games, one in-game exercise	3 hours
Study	Two exercises from chapter 3, one strong player's game paused	30 minutes
Session 2	Same as session 1, same in-game exercise	3 hours
Review	Notebook on two games, mistake families, post-mortem with a partner	30 minutes
Sessions 3 and 4	On the weekend, with a break in between	3 hours each
Day off	No TFT at all	The whole day

B. The pre-session checklist

- I slept enough, and I'm neither hungry nor thirsty.
- My phone is out of reach, no stream is running in the background.
- I have time to finish my games.
- I reread my three sheets, and did my patch routine if there is one.
- I did a warm-up exercise.
- I know my exercise of the day.
- I know my number of games and my stop signal.

And during the game, before each timer ends: board full, items placed, carry safe, nothing sold that I will regret.

Sources

Pages consulted in November 2026.

Chess players

- ChessCafe, Botvinnik's method: the 1927 loss, the match against Flohr, rest first, analysis with Model
- Business Standard, the role of seconds: preparing world championships, 2013
- ChessMood, Hrant Melkumyan's advice: preparation time, two repertoires
- Wikiquote, José Raúl Capablanca: study the endgame first, *Last Chess Lectures*
- Wikipedia, candidate move: Kotov's method
- Dan Heisman, checking for safety: "hope chess"
- Chess.com, prophylaxis: Nimzowitsch, Réti and the hypermodern school
- Chess.com, the post-mortem: the tradition, Anand and van Wely in 2007
- Perpetual Chess, recap of *The Seven Deadly Chess Sins*: Jonathan Rowson's seven sins

Body and sleep

- ESPN, the grandmasters' diet and its summary by Boing Boing: Polar's measurements, Robert Sapolsky, Fabiano Caruana
- Reader's Digest, how champions train physically: Caruana, Carlsen, Anand, 2022
- ScienceDaily, a sleepless night and risk-taking: study published in *Psychophysiology*, 2023
- GIGAZINE, stimulants and chess: study by Franke et al., *European Neuropsychopharmacology*, 2017

Research on expertise and error

- Burgoyne et al., 2019: reanalysis of Charness et al. (2005), meta-analysis by Hambrick et al. (2014)
- Notes on Chase and Simon, 1973: memory for positions, after de Groot
- Notes on Ericsson and Pool, *Peak*, 2016: deliberate practice
- MIT Technology Review, what causes blunders: Anderson, Kleinberg and Mullainathan, 2016

TFT

- What Remains When the Set Changes: our first book, for the notebook, the three questions, the patch routine and the price tables